Telling You How I Would Feel: Emotional Communication and Ambiguity in Trust

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Abstract

This paper examines how the opportunity to communicate anticipated happiness or disappointment affects trust decisions, beliefs about others' reciprocity, and ambiguity attitudes. In a preregistered experiment, 400 U.S.-based participants recruited through Prolific are randomly assigned to one of four conditions: no message, a message expressing anticipated happiness, a message expressing anticipated disappointment, or a choice between the two. I measure trust decisions in a modified trust game and use an incentivized belief-hedge method to distinguish beliefs, ambiguity aversion, and ambiguity-generated likelihood insensitivity. The main analysis includes 350 participants who pass both comprehension checks. I find no statistically significant effects on trust decisions. Relative to the no-message condition, choosing between the two messages increases expected returns and marginally reduces ambiguity aversion. When only the happiness message is available, expected returns increase marginally and neither measure of ambiguity attitudes changes significantly. When only the disappointment message is available, ambiguity-generated likelihood insensitivity falls, consistent with lower perceived ambiguity, while changes in expected returns and ambiguity aversion are statistically indistinguishable from zero. Taken together, the results provide suggestive evidence that opportunities to communicate anticipated emotions can change how people assess ambiguity about reciprocity.

1 Introduction

Does the opportunity to express how one expects to feel change one's willingness to trust? Consider a manager deciding whether to delegate a task to a colleague. Delegation may improve team performance, but the manager cannot fully monitor the colleague's effort or control the outcome (Brown et al., 2015; De Jong et al., 2016). Before handing over the task, the manager might tell the colleague that they would be happy if the work went well or disappointed if the colleague did not follow through. Whether the manager feels able to say either of these things depends in part on workplace norms. Some teams encourage managers to express positive feelings openly but discourage them from voicing disappointment, while others allow both or expect feedback to stay neutral (Hochschild, 1983; Kramer & Hess, 2002; Rafaeli & Sutton, 1987). To understand why these differences in norms might matter for trust, a first step is to ask whether having the

opportunity to express an anticipated emotion changes the decision to trust. I test this in a controlled experiment with trust game, by varying whether trustors can communicate anticipated happiness or disappointment to their counterpart before making their decision.

Trust involves uncertainty about another person's discretionary response. The person deciding whether to trust does not know how the other will respond or the probabilities of the possible responses. This makes trust a decision under social ambiguity (Bohnet & Zeckhauser, 2004; Li et al., 2019, 2020). Beliefs about reciprocity matter for this decision (Berg et al., 1995; Fehr, 2009), but beliefs alone may not explain willingness to trust. People who expect similar returns may differ in how they evaluate the uncertainty surrounding those returns.

I distinguish beliefs about reciprocity from two aspects of ambiguity attitudes. Expected return summarizes how much the trustor expects to receive. Ambiguity aversion captures reluctance to rely on unknown probabilities relative to known odds. Ambiguity-generated likelihood insensitivity, or *a-insensitivity*, is the tendency to give similar decision weights to events judged to differ in likelihood (Baillon et al., 2018; Dimmock et al., 2016; Li et al., 2019; Tversky & Fox, 1995). Greater a-insensitivity may weaken the link between beliefs and trust. For example, if communication makes a favorable return seem more likely, trustors with higher a-insensitivity may be less responsive to that change when deciding whether to trust.

Research on emotional expression has largely examined what recipients infer from others' expressions and how those expressions make them feel (Van Kleef, 2009; Van Kleef & Côté, 2022; Wubben et al., 2009). I examine how the opportunity to express one's own anticipated emotions affects the sender's decision. I hypothesize that access to emotional communication increases willingness to trust. First, trustors may expect higher returns if they believe their message will encourage reciprocity from the trustee. Second, having an opportunity to further engage in this interaction may give trustors a sense of agency and reduce ambiguity aversion, even at the same expected return (A. Berger & Tymula, 2022; Lind et al., 1990). Then trustors would be more willing to engage with this ambiguous event. Third, communication may lower a-insensitivity if it narrows the range of probabilities trustors consider plausible for each return (Henkel, 2024). Lower a-insensitivity can make trust decisions more responsive to both favorable and unfavorable beliefs.

I study this question in a preregistered online experiment that recruited 400 U.S. trustors. Each trustor chooses between *No Trust*, which gives both parties a certain, equal payment, and *Trust*, which creates a larger joint surplus but leaves the trustor's payoff dependent on the trustee's discretionary return. Before assignment, trustors privately report their anticipated happiness after reciprocity and disappointment after non-reciprocity. They are then randomly assigned to *Control*, where no message is available, or to a treatment that offers a happy message, a disappointed message, or a choice between the two. I refer to these treatments as *Restricted Happiness*, *Restricted Disappointment*, and *Flexible*. The message is selected before the trust decision and delivered if the trustor chooses Trust.

The experiment measures beliefs and ambiguity attitudes about the same trustee response that determines the payoff from Trust. After the trust decision, trustors complete an incentivized belief-hedge task that yields expected return, ambiguity aversion, and a-insensitivity (Baillon et al., 2018, 2021). This allows me to examine whether emotional communication affects each measure. Because the task follows the trust decision, it does not establish whether changes in these measures cause changes in Trust. Separately recruited trustees specify how much they would return if their matched

trustor chose Trust, after observing the applicable message. Their decisions allow me to examine trustee behavior alongside the returns trustors expect.

The estimates suggest that the opportunity to communicate anticipated emotions shapes trustors' beliefs and ambiguity attitudes, while the effects on Trust are imprecisely estimated. Relative to *Control*, trustors in *Flexible* expect to receive \$0.75 more when controling demographics. The expected-return estimates are also positive in *Restricted Happiness* and *Restricted Disappointment*, although only the *Flexible* estimate reaches the 5% significance. The estimates for ambiguity attitudes vary across treatments. Trustors become more ambiguity seeking in *Restricted Happiness* and *Flexible* compared with *Control*, and *Restricted Disappointment* leads to a reduction in a-insensitivity. The latter pattern suggests that access to a disappointed message may help trustors distinguish more sharply between events with different likelihoods.

The higher expected return in *Flexible* is similar when beliefs are estimated using a hierarchical Bayesian model, but smaller when the sample includes trustors who passed only one comprehension check. The exploratory heterogeneity results suggest that the expected-return response also varies across trustors. For example, it is larger in *Flexible* among trustors reporting stronger fairness preferences. These comparisons help describe whose expectations differ across conditions and how sensitive the estimates are to measurement and sample choices.

To relate these measures to the decision to trust, I examine whether trustors with more favorable beliefs or lower ambiguity aversion choose Trust more often. Both associations are present, consistent with the framework in Li et al. (2019). The interaction between expected return and a-insensitivity is imprecisely estimated. Since the measures are elicited after the decision, the estimates describe how beliefs and ambiguity attitudes relate to Trust. Trust is already common across conditions, with rates ranging from 82.4% to 88.6%.

Trustee behavior helps put the imprecise effects on Trust in context. Average actual returns range from \$10.55 to \$11.01 across conditions, with pronounced bunching between \$10 and \$12. This pattern is consistent with trustees using an approximately equal split as a benchmark for reciprocity. In *Restricted Happiness* and *Flexible*, the bunching shifts toward a higher focal point of \$12, exactly half the amount available to trustees. The share returning \$12 rises from 30% in *Control* to 45% in *Restricted Happiness* and 48% in *Flexible*, while remaining close to *Control* in *Restricted Disappointment*. In every treatment and message group, trustors on average expect less than their matched trustees return. The gap is statistically significant in *Control*, *Restricted Happiness*, and among *Flexible* trustors who choose disappointment. Even in *Control*, the average expected return is well above the \$3 at which Trust and No Trust yield the same payoff. This expected payoff advantage may help explain why Trust is already common in *Control* and why more favorable expectations under *Flexible* may change few trust decisions.

When trustors can choose between the two messages, 77 of 88 choose the happy message. Their chosen intensity usually matches what they reported privately before assignment. In open-ended responses, some trustors describe wanting to express how they would feel, while others describe trying to encourage reciprocity. These responses suggest that both expression and perceived influence matter to how trustors use the opportunity to communicate.

This paper adds to research on emotion and social decisions by examining how the opportunity to communicate a future emotional response affects the sender's current decision. It complements

research on how emotional expressions influence recipients by studying the willingness of the person expressing emotion to accept vulnerability. The messages combine anticipated emotion with references to reciprocity or non-reciprocity, so the effect of emotional wording alone remains open. The anonymous setting also leaves the role of repeated relationships and workplace norms for further study.

The rest of the paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 develops the framework linking emotional communication to expected return, ambiguity aversion, and a-insensitivity. Section 3 describes the preregistered experiment, the communication treatments, and the belief-hedge measure. Section 4 reports the main treatment effects, the associations between the uncertainty measures and Trust, and trustee responses. Section 5 examines exploratory differences across participants. The final sections discuss the scope of the findings and conclude. The appendix reports the preregistered comparisons, robustness checks, additional communication and trustee analyses, and supplementary heterogeneity results.

2 Framework

2.1 Trust as a Decision under Uncertainty

Trust can enable cooperation and create gains within an institution. Whether it benefits the person who trusts is less certain: choosing to trust makes that person vulnerable to another's discretionary response. Because the probabilities of possible responses are unknown, this choice involves social ambiguity (Bohnet & Zeckhauser, 2004; Corcos et al., 2012; Li et al., 2019).

Given this uncertainty, a person forms beliefs about the likelihood of each possible response. Beliefs that place more weight on favorable responses can make trust more attractive. Expected return summarizes these beliefs as the probability-weighted average of possible returns; a higher expected return can therefore support a greater willingness to trust.

Beyond this belief channel, how a person evaluates social ambiguity itself can also affect their willingness to trust. People differ in their willingness to engage with ambiguity about another person's response. Greater reluctance reflects greater ambiguity aversion. Thus, two people can hold the same beliefs about possible returns yet make different trust decisions.

The third aspect of the decision is how strongly a person distinguishes between event with different likelihoods. Ambiguity-generated insensitivity, or a-insensitivity, captures weak discrimination across these likelihood levels (Baillon et al., 2018; Li et al., 2019). It can weaken the connection between beliefs about another person's response and willingness to trust. Suppose communication of anticipated emotion increases the perceived likelihood of a favorable response enough to make an uncertain action the option with the higher expected monetary payoff. Someone with greater a-insensitivity may respond less to this change in belief and forgo that expected gain.

In their trust game, Li et al. (2019) find that people with more optimistic beliefs trust more often, while those with greater ambiguity aversion trust less often. They also find that a-insensitivity weakens the relationship between beliefs and trust. Communication about anticipated emotion

may affect both what a person expects from another's response and how they evaluate uncertainty about it.

2.2 Effects of Emotional Communication

Communication can shape social interactions even when it does not bind anyone to a particular action. It lets people convey information about themselves, reduce uncertainty about others, and influence how an interaction unfolds (C. R. Berger & Calabrese, 1975; Farrell & Rabin, 1996). Experimental evidence shows that communication can increase cooperation in social dilemmas and raise both trust and trustworthiness in exchange (Balliet, 2010; Ben-Ner et al., 2011). These effects make the opportunity to communicate relevant to a trustor's decision to become vulnerable to another person's response.

A trustor can communicate before the trustee acts by saying how the trustee's possible responses would make them feel. Such a message expresses an anticipated emotion, an emotion a person expects to experience if a possible outcome occurs (Loewenstein et al., 2001; Zeelenberg et al., 2000). In the experiment, trustors may communicate how they expect to feel if the trustee reciprocates or does not reciprocate. Random assignment to the control and treatments allows the experiment to estimate how access to this form of expression affects willingness to trust.

The experiment studies both positive and negative anticipated emotions. It uses happiness if the trustee reciprocates and disappointment if the trustee does not reciprocate their trust. Both are familiar emotions in social exchange, and expressions of happiness and disappointment can shape how others evaluate an interaction even when its material outcome is unchanged (Thompson et al., 1995). In the *Control*, trustors cannot communicate their anticipated emotions to trustees. The *Restricted Happiness* and *Restricted Disappointment* treatments let trustors choose the intensity of a structured message about only the assigned emotion. Comparing each treatment with the control estimates the effect of access to its specified message. The *Flexible* treatment lets trustors choose between the two messages and set their intensity, adding discretion over what to express. This added discretion matters because social settings differ in how much they constrain emotional expression (Kramer & Hess, 2002). The messages may affect both how trustees respond and what trustors expect them to return.

Actual and expected return. Messages about anticipated emotion may change actual and expected returns through the inferences and affective reactions they elicit. Van Kleef's emotions as social information model distinguishes the inferences recipients draw from emotional expressions from their affective reactions (Van Kleef, 2009). Either message may tell the trustee that reciprocity matters to the trustor and that the trustee's choice will affect the trustor's feelings. This inference may encourage a trustee who values a cooperative self-image to return more. Expressed disappointment has elicited concessions and cooperation, while positive emotional displays have sometimes encouraged concessions (Kopelman et al., 2006; Van Kleef et al., 2006; Wubben et al., 2009). The affective reactions may differ. A happy message may evoke warmth, whereas a disappointed message may evoke discomfort or defensiveness if heard as blame (Van Kleef & Côté, 2022). The cited studies examine emotions presented as already felt. Whether messages about anticipated emotions elicit similar responses remains an empirical question.

If trustors believe that each emotional message will induce trustees to return more, they should expect a higher return in all three treatments than in the *Control*. The *Flexible* treatment also lets them choose the message they expect to elicit the larger return. If trustors choose messages to maximize their expected monetary return, this discretion may raise expected return above that in either restricted treatment. When emotional communication leads trustors to expect more favorable returns, they may become more willing to trust.

Ambiguity aversion. The opportunity to communicate anticipated emotion may give trustors a sense of agency in an interaction whose outcome they cannot determine. Sharing how they expect to feel may therefore reduce ambiguity aversion even without control over the trustee's decision. Research on procedural voice finds that being able to express a view improves fairness judgments even when people cannot control the final outcome (Lind et al., 1990). Trustors may also feel able to influence the trustee by making the emotional consequences of the trustee's choice visible. Evidence that perceived control can change choices under ambiguity supports this possibility (A. Berger & Tymula, 2022). If this sense of agency makes the uncertain interaction easier to accept without changing expected return, it offers a route to lower ambiguity aversion. The *Flexible* treatment adds choice over which emotion to express, although responsibility for that choice may offset the benefit.

Trustors may also anticipate how the trustee will feel on receiving their message, since emotional expressions can elicit affective reactions in recipients (Van Kleef, 2009). A happy message may be expected to evoke warmth, while a disappointed message may evoke concern or defensiveness. Anticipating a warm or strained exchange could make the uncertain interaction feel more or less comfortable to the trustor, even if expected monetary return remains unchanged.

The agency to communicate anticipated emotion and beliefs about how the trustee will receive the message motivate the hypothesis that access to emotional communication reduces ambiguity aversion, although the balance of these effects may differ across treatments.

A-insensitivity. More precise beliefs about the trustee's response provide a possible route to lower a-insensitivity. Henkel (2024) finds that lower perceived ambiguity leads to lower a-insensitivity. Henkel measures perceived ambiguity through the width of subjective probability intervals. Choosing a message may help trustors anticipate the trustee's response. A happy message may make generous returns seem more likely. A disappointed message may make less generous returns seem more likely. Either message may also narrow the range of probabilities trustors consider plausible for each return. I therefore hypothesize that emotional communication generally reduces a-insensitivity.

Choice of intensity. The emotional communication treatments allow trustors to choose the intensity of their message: *slightly*, *moderately*, or *very*. Intensity is part of emotional expression. Intensity choice is especially important when the message is structured and its valence is assigned. It gives trustors a meaningful role in deciding what to communicate and preserves the sense of agency central to the research question.

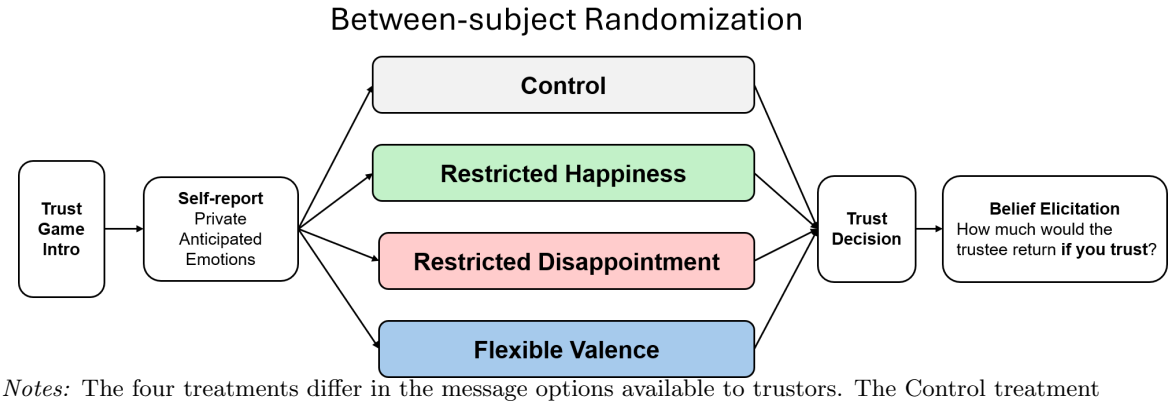
Intensity choice also allows me to study how trustors communicate their anticipated emotions. Before treatment assignment, trustors privately report how strongly they expect to feel happiness and disappointment. Their later message choice can be compared with this private report. A stronger communicated intensity may indicate amplification, while a weaker intensity may indicate restraint. These patterns show how trustors adjust emotional expression when a message will be seen by the trustee.

The final trust decision. The expected-return and ambiguity-attitude channels lead to the overall prediction that access to emotional communication increases *Trust*. Expected return may rise because trustors believe that communicating their anticipated emotion can influence the trustee's response. Ambiguity aversion may fall because communicating anticipated emotion gives trustors a sense of agency in the interaction. Emotional communication may also lower a-insensitivity by narrowing the range of probabilities trustors consider plausible for each return. Lower a-insensitivity does not have a fixed effect on Trust. It strengthens the effect of favorable beliefs, but it can also strengthen the effect of unfavorable beliefs.

3 Experimental Design

This study uses a preregistered online experiment to examine how emotional communication affects trust and uncertainty about a counterpart's response. In the experiment, participants act as trustors and choose between a certain allocation and a trust option whose payoff depends on a separately recruited trustee's return. The experiment begins with trust-game instructions and a comprehension check, continues with pretreatment emotion reports, assignment to one of four between-subject treatments (Control, Restricted Happiness, Restricted Disappointment, or Flexible), and the trust decision, and concludes with an incentivized belief-hedge task, a second comprehension check, and a questionnaire on demographics, social preferences, and emotion-related traits. The trustor sample comprises 400 participants recruited through Prolific. All participants were U.S. residents. Trustees complete a separate, anonymous task in which they state contingent return decisions using the strategy method.

Figure 1: Experimental flow.



Notes: The four treatments differ in the message options available to trustors. The Control treatment provides no message. The Restricted Happiness treatment allows trustors to choose the intensity of a happy message. The Restricted Disappointment treatment allows trustors to choose the intensity of a disappointed message. The Flexible treatment allows trustors to choose both message valence and intensity.

3.1 Design Strategy: Communication Access, Message Choice, and Influence

The central design problem is to identify the effect of giving a trustor access to anticipated-emotional communication. Inducing an emotional state would identify the effect of experiencing that emotion, while assigning a fixed message would identify how recipients respond to predetermined content. Neither approach identifies the sender-side effect studied here: whether having an expressive option changes the decision to accept vulnerability. The experiment therefore randomizes the communication options available to trustors while preserving their choice over intensity and, in Flexible, valence (Andrade & Ho, 2009; Baillon et al., 2016; Qin et al., 2024; Van Kleef et al., 2004). The randomized comparisons identify the effects of the communication rules; the messages selected within those rules describe how participants use the available options.

The design also separates privately anticipated emotion from recipient-facing expression. Before treatment assignment, all trustors report how they expect to feel following reciprocity and non-reciprocity. Because these reports precede information about the communication regime, they provide a common benchmark that is not tailored to a particular message opportunity. Message selections occur only after assignment and may reflect both anticipated feelings and strategic considerations. The comparison between reports and selections is therefore informative about how private anticipation is translated into communication, without treating either measure as verified emotional experience.

A further challenge is to measure uncertainty about the relevant social source. Ambiguity attitudes can differ across uncertainty generated by nature, deliberate human choice, and strategic interaction (Li et al., 2019, 2020). The belief-hedge task is therefore defined directly over the matched trustee's return rather than over an unrelated artificial event. It separates expected returns from ambiguity aversion and a-insensitivity for the same source that determines the payoff from Trust. The design measures the combined ambiguity attached to the trustee's strategic social response; it does not separately identify general social ambiguity from the additional ambiguity generated by strategic interaction.

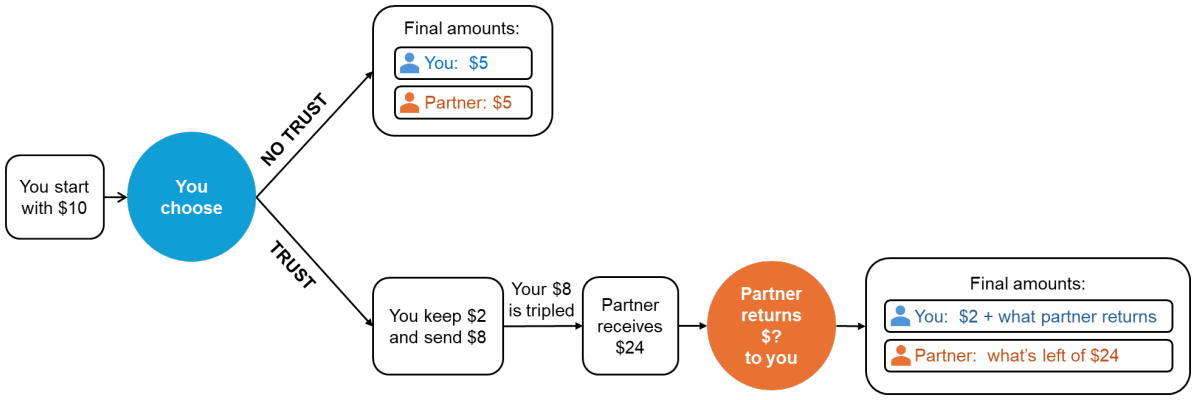
Finally, the design separates perceived from realized influence. The belief-hedge task measures the trustee return anticipated by the trustor, while separately recruited trustees provide the corresponding return decisions under the relevant message categories. Administering the belief task after the trust decision prevents the elicitation from preceding and potentially shaping the focal choice. Consequently, these measures are randomized treatment outcomes rather than identified mediators. Together, the design identifies the effects of communication access and form, describes endogenous message use, and compares the influence trustors anticipate with the behavior trustees realize.

3.2 Modified Trust Game

The modified trust game captures the central trade-off in a trust decision. Multiplying the transfer creates a potential efficiency gain, but trusting makes the trustor vulnerable to the trustee's return decision. A purely self-interested trustee would return zero, and a risk-neutral, payoff-maximizing trustor prefers Trust only when its expected payoff exceeds the certain alternative. The choice may therefore depend on the trustor's beliefs about the trustee's return and attitude toward uncertainty, which are elicited after the game. The main task uses a binary choice so that every trustor evaluates the same trust prospect (Figure 2), building on related work on trust under ambiguity (Bohnet & Zeckhauser, 2004; Li et al., 2019, 2020).

Each trustor receives a \$10 endowment and chooses between *Trust* and *No Trust*. Under No Trust, the trustor and trustee each receive \$5, and the game ends without a trustee decision. This certain, equal split involves no ambiguity and reduces the likelihood that fairness preferences make No Trust unattractive. Under Trust, the trustor keeps \$2 and sends \$8, which is tripled so that the trustee receives \$24. The trustee chooses a return $r \in [0, 24]$, giving final payoffs of $2 + r$ for the trustor and $24 - r$ for the trustee. Trust pays the trustor more than No Trust when the trustee returns more than \$3, but the return is unknown when the trustor chooses. Fixing this single Trust option standardizes the uncertain prospect and improves the comparability of the later belief and ambiguity-attitude measures across treatments.

Figure 2: Payoffs in the modified trust game.



3.3 Self-Reflection and Emotional-Communication Treatments

After learning the trust game and passing the comprehension questions, trustors enter a self-reflection stage. They report their anticipated feelings in two scenarios. The prompts reproduce the wording used in the experiment:

- "If you choose trust, and your partner reciprocates your trust, how happy would you feel."
- "If you choose trust, and your partner does not reciprocate your trust, how disappointed would you feel?"

Each anticipated emotion is reported at one of three intensity levels: *slightly*, *moderately*, or *very*.

The reports are elicited before treatment assignment, when trustors have no information about the later communication opportunity. They therefore capture anticipated feelings independently of condition-specific message choices. The self-reflection and communication tasks remain comparable because both concern anticipated emotional responses to the same hypothetical reciprocation outcomes.

The design uses happiness following reciprocation and disappointment following non-reciprocation because both emotions map directly onto the two outcomes and are natural to communicate. Anger may carry a higher psychological or social cost as a strategic message. The messages refer to reciprocation without specifying a return amount, leaving trustees to choose over the full return range without a numerical anchor.

After the self-reflection stage, trustors are randomly assigned to one of four treatments:

- **Control.** No emotional message is available.
- **Restricted Happiness.** The trustor selects the intensity of the following happy message: "If you reciprocate my trust, I would be [slightly/moderately/very] happy."
- **Restricted Disappointment.** The trustor selects the intensity of the following disappointed message: "If you do not reciprocate my trust, I would be [slightly/moderately/very] disappointed."
- **Flexible.** The trustor chooses between the happiness and disappointed messages and then selects its intensity.

In the three communication treatments, trustors select a message before choosing Trust or No Trust. The selected message is shown to the matched trustee only if the trustor chooses Trust, after which the trustee states a contingent return under the relevant communication condition. The applicable paired choices are payoff-relevant when that contingency is realized.

The restricted treatments hold message valence fixed while allowing trustors to choose among three ordered intensity levels. This active choice gives trustors a meaningful role within the assigned

communication rule and makes the communication opportunity salient. The Control condition represents the absence of an emotional message. Within the communication treatments, every option states an emotion because an unstated emotion—for example, the absence of happiness—can carry either neutral or negative meaning.

Using the same emotions and intensity scale in the self-reflection and communication tasks permits an exploratory comparison of anticipated feelings and selected messages, including whether trustors amplify or downplay an emotion when communicating it. In the Flexible treatment, trustees observe only the selected message, creating a common recipient information structure across the flexible- and restricted-message treatments. After learning their communication condition and selecting a message when applicable, all trustors decide whether to trust, concluding the modified trust game.

3.4 Belief-Hedge Elicitation

The belief-hedge stage measures trustors' beliefs about the trustee's return and their attitudes toward ambiguity (Baillon et al., 2018, 2021). All trustors complete this stage after the trust game and evaluate how much the trustee would return from the \$24 transfer. The strategy method makes the task relevant after either trust decision. Both choices also lead to the same sequence of subsequent tasks and participation fee, keeping completion incentives constant across choices.

Trustors repeatedly choose between an ambiguous bet and a risky lottery. The ambiguous bet pays \$5 when an event about the trustee's return occurs, whereas the lottery pays the same amount with a known probability p. I vary this probability until the trustor is approximately indifferent, yielding the event's *matching probability*. For example, a trustor chooses between receiving \$5 if $r < 6$ and receiving \$5 with a stated objective probability. The elicitation covers low, intermediate, and high return events and their complements: $\{r < 6\}$, $\{6 \leq r \leq 9\}$, and $\{r > 9\}$.

The matching probabilities yield three measures of uncertainty about the trustee's return:

- **Expected return, $E(r)$.** This is a weighted average of the three return ranges:

$$E(r) = 2.5p_L + 7.5p_M + 17p_H,$$

  where p_L, p_M, and p_H are the trustor's a-neutral probabilities for the low, intermediate, and high ranges. The coefficients 2.5, 7.5, and 17 are the respective midpoints of \$0 to \$5, \$6 to \$9, and \$10 to \$24.

- **Ambiguity aversion, b.** This index measures the trustor's aversion to uncertainty about how much the matched trustee would return, separately from beliefs about which returns are more likely. A larger value indicates stronger aversion: $b > 0$ indicates ambiguity aversion, $b = 0$ neutrality, and $b < 0$ ambiguity seeking.

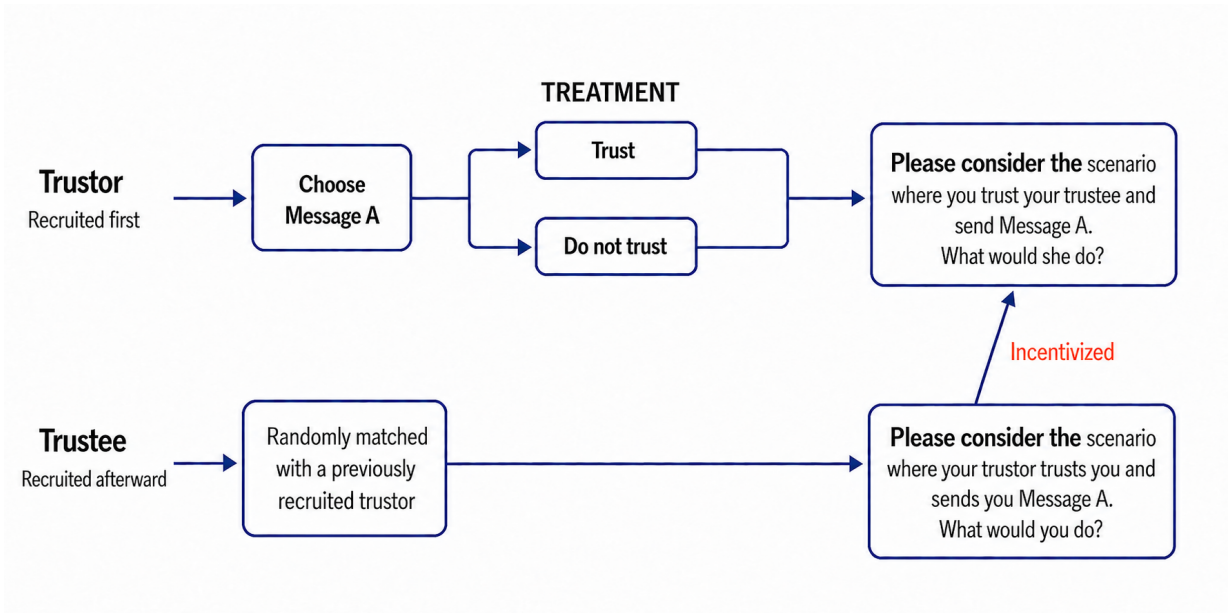
- **A-insensitivity, a.** This dimension of ambiguity attitudes measures how weakly the trustor's valuation responds to differences in the perceived likelihood of the matched trustee's possible returns. A higher value indicates less sensitivity to likelihood differences among the low, intermediate, and high return events.

At the end of the experiment, participants completed a questionnaire on demographics, social preferences, and emotional intelligence. The social-preference measures capture participant's fairness preference and reciprocity preference. The emotional-intelligence index includes four self-reported measures: appraisal of one's own emotions, appraisal of others' emotions, emotion regulation, and emotional labor. The appendix (xx) reports the questionnaire wording and explains how the measures are constructed.

3.5 Incentives and Matching

Each trustor received a \$4 participation fee, and one of the trustor's incentivized decisions was selected at random to determine the bonus payment. If the trust game was selected, No Trust paid the trustor \$5, while Trust paid \$2 plus the matched trustee's return r. If a belief hedge decision was selected, the option chosen by the trustor was played out. For an objective lottery, a number was drawn uniformly from 1 to 100, and the trustor received \$5 if the number did not exceed the stated winning percentage and \$0 otherwise. For an event bet, the matched trustee's actual return was checked against the specified return range or ranges, and the trustor received \$5 if the return fell within that range or those ranges and \$0 otherwise. These payment rules fully incentivized both the trust game and the belief elicitation task. Trustors earned an average bonus of approximately \$4.40, and mean completion time was 17.7 minutes.[1]

Figure 3: Trustor and trustee flow.



Notes: The trustor chooses a message when the assigned treatment permits one, decides whether to trust, and then faces the incentivized belief-elicitation task. Trustees are recruited afterward, matched to trustors, and state contingent return decisions for the relevant message category.

After the trustor and trustee sessions were completed, each trustor was randomly matched one to

[1] Appendix Table 17 reports completion times by treatment. Completion time did not differ systematically between trustors choosing Trust and No Trust, either overall or within treatments (Appendix Table 19).

one with a trustee assigned to the same message category, defined by Control or by the selected emotion and intensity. Using the strategy method, the trustee had stated how much they would return if the matched trustor chose Trust and, when applicable, after receiving the selected emotional message. This return determined the trust game payoff when that decision was selected and resolved any selected belief hedge event defined over the trustee's return. Trustees observed only the information relevant to the matched condition, not message options that were unavailable to the trustor. After observing the applicable message, trustees also reported how strongly they felt happiness, gratitude, guilt, sadness, and anger on a five-point scale. These measures capture their emotional responses to the message. Random matching therefore preserved incentives while allowing the two sessions to be conducted separately. The matched returns also provide a behavioral benchmark for comparing the influence anticipated by trustors with the influence realized in trustee behavior.

4 Main Results

4.1 Pre-registration and deviations

This study was pre-registered in the AEA RCT Registry (AEARCTR-0018300). The pre-analysis plan specified three main comparisons: pooled emotional communication versus *Control*, *Restricted Happiness* versus *Restricted Disappointment*, and *Flexible* versus pooled restricted treatments. These comparisons examine access to emotional communication, differences between restricted valences, and flexibility in choosing valence, respectively. However, they do not directly assess how different access to emotional communication affects behavior relative to no communication, which is central to the paper's focus on the opportunity. I therefore depart from the pre-registered specification by including a separate indicator for each emotional treatment in the outcome regressions, with *Control* as the reference group. The original preregistered comparisons are reported in Appendix Section A. Appendix Section B reports measurement and sample sensitivity analyses. Exploratory analyses of treatment heterogeneity by cultural background and occupation were added after pre-registration.

4.2 Sample and Balance Checks

The experiment recruited 400 trustors, with approximately 100 participants assigned to each condition. The main sample contains 350 trustors who passed all comprehension checks. Exclusion rates are similar across the four randomized conditions (Pearson $\chi^2(3) = 0.61$, $p = 0.894$). Control variables are balanced across conditions in the main sample (joint multinomial-logit Wald test, $\chi^2(111) = 77.26$, $p = 0.994$). The balance tables are reported in Appendix Section C.

4.3 Self-Reported and Communicated Anticipated Emotions

Before condition assignment, participants reported their anticipated happiness and disappointment. Most participants anticipated strong feelings of both emotions, with greater happiness than disappointment. Both intensity measures are balanced across the four conditions, as shown in Table 1.

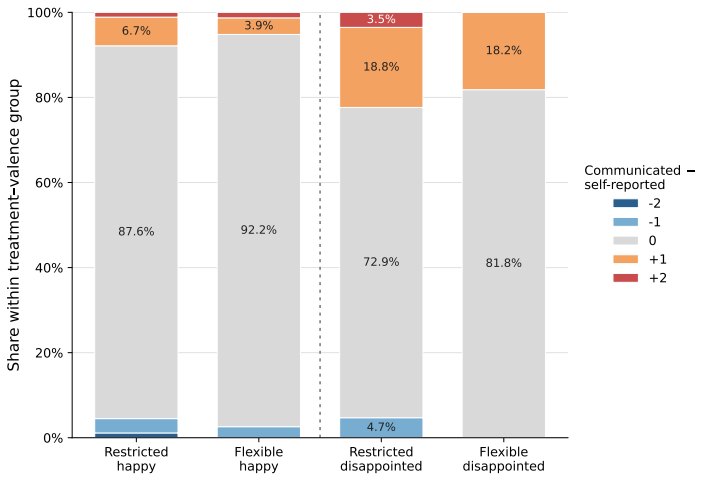
Table 1: Balance Check: Self-Reported Intensities

Emotion	Intensity	Main sample	Control	Restricted Happiness	Restricted Disappointment	Flexible	p-value
Anticipated happiness	Slightly	3.7%	5.7%	3.4%	2.4%	3.4%	
	Moderately	9.4%	11.4%	10.1%	11.8%	4.5%	0.551
	Very	86.9%	83.0%	86.5%	85.9%	92.0%	
Anticipated disappointment	Slightly	12.3%	12.5%	13.5%	14.1%	9.1%	
	Moderately	32.9%	25.0%	33.7%	40.0%	33.0%	0.373
	Very	54.9%	62.5%	52.8%	45.9%	58.0%	

Notes: The table reports the distribution of pretreatment self-reported anticipated-emotion intensities in the main sample and by randomized treatment. The p-values are from Pearson chi-squared tests of independence between treatment assignment and the categorical intensity measure.

In *Flexible*, 77 of the 88 (87.5%) participants in the main sample choose to send a happy message. Across the communication treatments, participants most often choose the highest available intensity (81.7% across all emotional treatments). Figure 4 shows how communicated intensity differs from the corresponding self-reported intensity. Most participants communicate an intensity that matches their self-report. Among those who depart from it, amplification is more common than suppression.[2]

Figure 4: Emotional expression deviation by experimental condition and valence.



Notes: The figure uses the main sample. Emotional expression deviation equals communicated intensity minus the corresponding self-reported intensity. Negative values indicate suppression, zero indicates no change, and positive values indicate amplification. Bars show percentages within each condition and valence group.

[2]The greater frequency of amplification for disappointment may partly reflect a ceiling effect, since many participants already report the highest possible happiness intensity before treatment assignment.

Together, these patterns suggest that participants understand the emotional communication options and engage with them meaningfully. Their communicated intensities usually match their self-reported intensities, and most choose happiness when given a choice of valence. Open-ended explanations further support this interpretation: participants describe choosing messages both to express their anticipated feelings and to encourage reciprocity. Appendix Section D.1 provides further evidence on their reasons for choosing message intensity.

Communicated valence and intensity are endogenous choices made after treatment assignment. I therefore do not include them as controls in the main treatment-effect regressions. I return to these choices in the discussion about what factors may affect participants emotional communicaiton decisions.

4.4 Outcomes by Communication Environment

Table 2 reports condition means for the main sample. The table also reports means by selected message within *Flexible*.

Table 2: Descriptive Statistics by Treatment: Main Sample

	Main Sample	Control	Restricted Happiness	Restricted Disappointment	Flexible	Flexible (Happiness)	Flexible (Disappointment)
Trust	0.85	0.83	0.84	0.82	0.89	0.92	0.64
	(0.36)	(0.38)	(0.37)	(0.38)	(0.32)	(0.27)	(0.50)
Expected return[a]	9.83	9.48	9.96	9.75	10.13	10.33	8.76
($)	(2.86)	(2.44)	(2.86)	(2.92)	(3.17)	(3.11)	(3.40)
Ambiguity aversion	-0.07	-0.03	-0.10	-0.03	-0.12	-0.12	-0.09
(b-index)	(0.33)	(0.33)	(0.34)	(0.32)	(0.33)	(0.34)	(0.19)
A-insensitivity	0.36	0.41	0.34	0.29	0.41	0.41	0.42
(a-index)	(0.38)	(0.37)	(0.36)	(0.40)	(0.38)	(0.39)	(0.34)
N (Trust, b, and a)	350	88	89	85	88	77	11
N (Expected return)	341	84	89	83	85	74	11

Notes: The table reports means of the main outcomes with standard deviations in parentheses. The *Flexible (Happiness)* and *Flexible (Disappointment)* columns split the Flexible treatment by self-selected message valence. The main sample consists of participants who passed both comprehension checks. [a]Expected return is reported for 341 participants; nine did not yield a valid set of subjective probabilities for its construction. The first N row applies to Trust, ambiguity aversion (b), and a-insensitivity; the second applies to expected return.

The average trust rate is high across all four conditions, ranging from 82% in *Restricted Disappointment* to 89% in *Flexible*. Mean expected returns are higher in the emotional communication treatments than in *Control*, while differences in ambiguity attitudes vary across conditions. I examine these condition differences for each outcome below.

Expected Return The mean expected return is \$9.95 under pooled emotional communication, compared with \$9.48 in *Control*, a difference of \$0.47 ($p = 0.074$).[3] The largest estimated increase occurs in *Flexible*, where the mean is \$10.13, or \$0.65 higher than in *Control* ($p = 0.068$). The estimated increases under *Restricted Happiness* and *Restricted Disappointment* are smaller ($p =$

[3]Mean comparisons for expected return and the ambiguity indices use one-sided Welch t-tests.

0.117 and $p = 0.256$). The estimated differences are therefore in the predicted direction, although not statistically significant at the 5% level.

Ambiguity Aversion In *Control*, the mean ambiguity-aversion index is close to zero (-0.03, 95% CI [-0.11, 0.04]), consistent with ambiguity neutrality. The pooled emotional communication groups have a slightly more negative mean (-0.08), a difference of -0.05 index points relative to *Control* (one-sided $p = 0.127$). The mean in *Restricted Disappointment* is also -0.03, showing little difference relative to *Control* ($p = 0.536$). By contrast, the means are more negative in *Restricted Happiness* (-0.10, $p = 0.111$) and *Flexible* (-0.12, $p = 0.052$), corresponding to differences of -0.07 and -0.09 index points, respectively. These estimates suggest greater ambiguity seeking in the latter two treatments, although the differences from *Control* are not statistically significant at the 5% level.

A-insensitivity Mean a-insensitivity is lower under pooled emotional communication than in *Control* (0.35 versus 0.41), a difference of -0.06 index points that is not statistically significant (one-sided $p = 0.104$). The lower mean is concentrated mainly in the restricted treatments, especially *Restricted Disappointment*, where the mean is 0.29 ($p = 0.028$). This corresponds to a reduction of 0.12 index points relative to *Control*. In contrast, the mean in *Flexible* is similar to that in *Control* (0.41, $p = 0.537$). The clearest evidence of lower a-insensitivity is therefore in *Restricted Disappointment*.

Trust The pooled emotional communication group has an average trust rate of 85.1%, compared with 83.0% in *Control*, an estimated increase of 2.1 percentage points ($p = 0.314$).[4] The treatment-specific differences relative to *Control* are 1.3 percentage points for *Restricted Happiness* ($p = 0.407$), -0.6 percentage points for *Restricted Disappointment* ($p = 0.542$), and 5.7 percentage points for *Flexible* ($p = 0.140$). Taken together, the descriptive results show higher mean expected returns and lower ambiguity indices in some treatments, but provide no statistically clear evidence of an average increase in trust.

Regression Results Table 3 reports regressions without controls and with demographic controls. Overall, the results are consistent with the descriptive patterns. Expected return has positive coefficients in all three emotional communication treatments. The estimate is largest under *Flexible* and reaches the 5% level, while the estimate under *Restricted Happiness* is suggestive at the 10% level. For ambiguity aversion, the negative coefficients under *Restricted Happiness* and *Flexible* indicate greater ambiguity seeking, although neither reaches the 5% level. For a-insensitivity, the coefficients are negative in both restricted treatments, with the clearest evidence under *Restricted Disappointment*. The estimate under *Flexible* is close to zero. For the trust decision, the coefficients for *Restricted Happiness* and *Flexible* are positive, while the coefficient for *Restricted Disappointment* is close to zero. None of the trust estimates is statistically significant.[5]

[4] Comparisons of trust rates use one-sided two-sample proportion tests.

[5] Adding fairness and reciprocity preferences and emotional-intelligence measures yields broadly similar estimates (Appendix Table 16).

Table 3: Main Regression Results by Communication Condition

	Expected return		Ambiguity aversion		**a**-insensitivity		Trust	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Restricted Happiness	0.482	0.636*	-0.062	-0.065	-0.069	-0.058	0.013	0.019
	(0.403)	(0.414)	(0.051)	(0.053)	(0.055)	(0.060)	(0.056)	(0.056)
Restricted Disappointment	0.274	0.354	0.005	0.012	-0.113**	-0.092*	-0.006	0.001
	(0.416)	(0.439)	(0.050)	(0.050)	(0.059)	(0.062)	(0.058)	(0.058)
Flexible	0.650*	0.745**	-0.081*	-0.082*	0.005	0.007	0.057	0.047
	(0.435)	(0.450)	(0.049)	(0.057)	(0.057)	(0.061)	(0.053)	(0.053)
Intercept	9.475	10.175	-0.035	-0.149	0.408	0.437	0.830	0.854
	(0.266)	(0.876)	(0.035)	(0.114)	(0.040)	(0.119)	(0.040)	(0.112)
Controls	No	Yes	No	Yes	No	Yes	No	Yes
Adjusted R^2	-0.002	-0.010	0.004	0.002	0.008	0.001	-0.004	-0.001
Observations	341	341	350	350	350	350	350	350

Notes: Columns report OLS regressions with the three treatment indicators, without controls and with demographic controls. Treatment-versus-Control tests are one-sided in the hypothesized direction. Robust standard errors are in parentheses. Significance levels are * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, and *** $p < 0.01$.

The sensitivity checks distinguish two findings. Under *Flexible*, the controlled expected-return estimate is similar when beliefs are recovered using the hierarchical Bayesian model ($0.77 versus $0.75), but falls to $0.41 when participants who passed only one comprehension check are included. The positive estimate therefore persists across these checks, with its magnitude more sensitive to sample inclusion than to the way beliefs are recovered. Under *Restricted Disappointment*, the negative a-insensitivity estimate is similar in the broader sample and smaller under Bayesian measurement. This supports the direction of the disappointment result while leaving its magnitude uncertain. Trust effects remain imprecise in the broader sample. Appendix Sections B.2 and B.3 report the estimates.

4.5 Linking Data to the Framework

I next examine whether expected return, ambiguity aversion, and a-insensitivity are associated with the trust decision as proposed in the framework. Following Li et al. (2019), I regress the trust decision on these three factors and include an interaction between expected return and a-insensitivity, as the framework suggests that a-insensitivity weakens the link between beliefs and decisions. These coefficients describe associations and do not identify causal mediation.

Consistent with the results in Li et al. (2019), Table 4 shows that higher expected returns and lower ambiguity aversion are associated with a greater willingness to trust. These relationships are stable across specifications, while neither a-insensitivity nor its interaction with expected return is statistically significant. Overall, these associations are broadly consistent with the framework. They suggest that beliefs and ambiguity attitudes may help explain individual trust decisions even when the average treatment effect on trust is not statistically clear. The positive belief–trust association also appears when beliefs are summarized by optimism, the probability gap between high and low returns. The negative association with ambiguity aversion likewise persists, while the interaction with a-insensitivity remains imprecise (Appendix Section B.1).

Table 4: Trust Associations with Belief and Ambiguity Measures

	Trust				
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Expected return		0.033***	0.031***	0.033***	0.030***
		(0.007)	(0.007)	(0.009)	(0.010)
Ambiguity aversion	-0.183***		-0.153**	-0.155**	-0.168**
	(0.064)		(0.062)	(0.063)	(0.068)
A-insensitivity	0.007		0.026	0.074	0.075
	(0.060)		(0.059)	(0.209)	(0.212)
Expected return × A-insensitivity				-0.005	-0.006
				(0.019)	(0.019)
Controls	No	No	No	No	Yes
Adjusted R-squared	0.022	0.066	0.080	0.078	0.068
Observations	341	341	341	341	341

Notes: All regressions use linear probability models, with robust standard errors in parentheses. Trust is a binary value that equals to one when the participants chose to trust. Main sample is used in the analysis. The coefficients indicate associations and do not identify causal mediation. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

4.6 Trustee Response

Having examined the treatment effects on trustors, I now turn to trustees' emotional responses and return decisions. These outcomes show how trustees respond to the emotional messages and provide a benchmark for trustors' expected returns.

Trustee Emotional Response Table 5 shows that disappointed messages are associated with lower reported happiness and gratitude and higher guilt, sadness, anger, and sympathy relative to *Control*. Happy messages do not differ significantly from *Control* for most emotions, although trustees report more sympathy and marginally more guilt. Although the messages describe anticipated rather than currently felt emotions, trustees nevertheless report different emotional responses across message valences. This pattern is consistent with the affective channel proposed in the emotions-as-social-information framework (Van Kleef, 2009). It suggests that trustees responded emotionally to the messages, especially when they communicated anticipated disappointment.

Table 5: Trustee Emotional Responses by Message Valence

Response	Control	Happy	Disappointed
Happy	3.97	3.81	2.51***
Grateful	3.99	3.83	2.75***
Guilty	1.26	1.40*	2.28***
Sad	1.11	1.14	1.72***
Angry	1.12	1.07	1.27**
Sympathetic	2.70	3.09**	3.03*
Observations	115	212	133

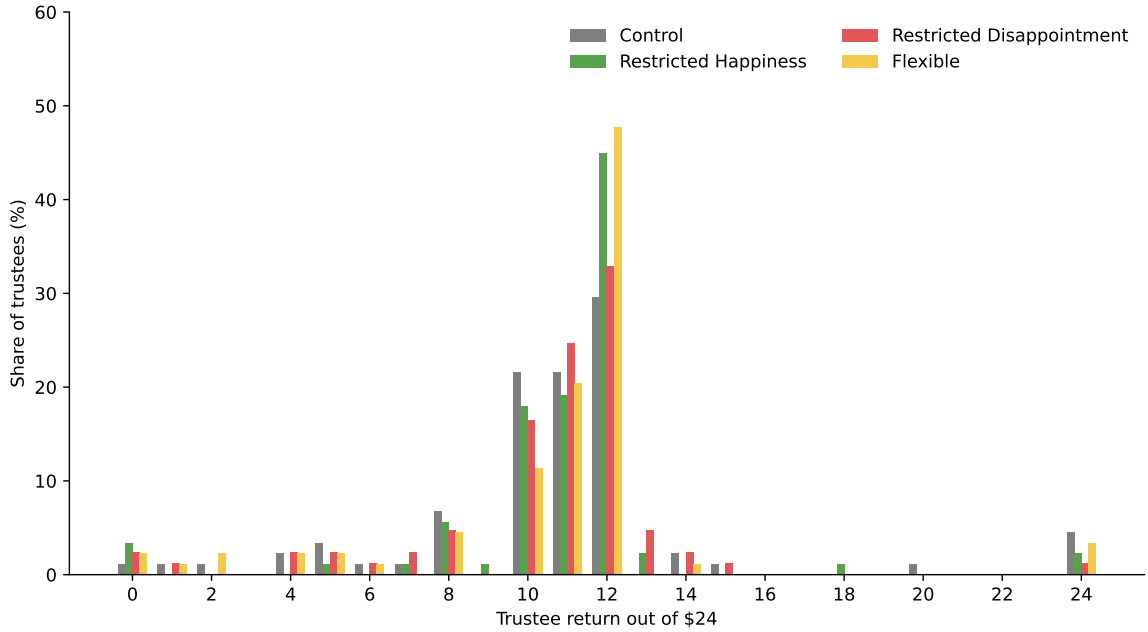
Notes: Responses are coded from 1 (not at all) to 5 (extremely). Happy and disappointed pool all three communicated intensity levels. Stars on the Happy and Disappointed means indicate that the two-sided Mann–Whitney test rejects equality with Control at the 10% (*), 5% (**), or 1% (***) level.

Trustee Returns Trustees state how much they would return if the matched trustor chose Trust, after observing the selected message or no message in *Control*. Average actual returns are similar across experimental conditions: \$10.88 in *Control*, \$11.01 in *Restricted Happiness* ($p = 0.180$),

$10.55 in *Restricted Disappointment* ($p = 0.574$), and $10.78 in *Flexible* ($p = 0.191$).[6]

Despite the similar average returns, Figure 5 shows differences in the return distributions. Returns are concentrated between $10 and $12 in all conditions, with a more pronounced concentration at $12 under *Restricted Happiness* and *Flexible*. The share returning $12 increases from 30% in *Control* to 45% and 48%, respectively (two-sided Fisher exact tests, both $p < 0.05$). Under *Restricted Disappointment*, this share remains close to *Control*.[7]

Figure 5: Distribution of actual trustee returns by randomized trustor condition.



Notes: Bars show the percentage of matched trustee returns at each dollar amount, calculated separately within each randomized condition. The sample comprises the 350 trustors who passed both comprehension checks.

The concentration of returns around half of the available amount is consistent with reciprocity, with several amounts potentially serving as focal points. Returning $12 divides the $24 equally, whereas returning $11 equalizes the players' final payoffs. Returning $10 may also be salient as a round number. The greater concentration at $12 under *Restricted Happiness* and *Flexible* may suggest that emotional messages shift weight toward a higher focal return.

Expected versus Actual Returns Table 6 reports the difference between trustors' expected returns and the actual returns of their matched trustees. Expected returns are lower than actual returns in every treatment–valence cell. In *Control*, trustors underestimate returns by $1.41 on average. Within *Flexible*, the gap is smallest among trustors who choose the happy message ($0.24) and largest among those who choose the disappointed message ($2.79). These results suggest that trustors generally underestimate trustee returns, although the extent of underestimation varies

[6] p-values here report two-sided Mann–Whitney tests comparing each communication treatment with *Control*.
[7] Appendix Table 23 reports the corresponding distributional statistics and return shares.

Table 6: Expected and Actual Returns by Treatment and Valence

Treatment	Valence	Expected return ($)	Actual return ($)	Expected − actual ($)
Control	–	9.48	10.88	-1.41**
Restricted Happiness	Happy	9.96	11.01	-1.05**
Restricted Disappointment	Disappointed	9.75	10.54	-0.79
Flexible	Happy	10.33	10.57	-0.24
	Disappointed	8.76	11.55	-2.79**

Notes: Entries report means. Expected − actual is the within-trustor difference between the stated expected return and the return of the randomly matched trustee. Stars report two-sided one-sample t-tests: $^{***}p < 0.01$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{*}p < 0.10$. The table uses complete expected-return/actual-return pairs from the main sample. Valence refers to the message communicated to the trustee.

across treatments and message choices.

5 Heterogeneity Analysis

The main results suggest that emotional communication can shape expected returns and ambiguity attitudes, while its effects on Trust are imprecisely estimated. I examine whether these responses vary with how participants understand emotions, value the social interaction, and experience norms around emotional expression.

5.1 Emotional Intelligence and Social Preferences

Emotional intelligence is relevant to the belief channel because trustors must anticipate how the trustee will respond to an emotional message. Participants who differ in understanding and managing emotions may therefore differ in the influence they expect communication to have. In Table 7, higher reported emotional intelligence is associated with a smaller expected-return effect of pooled communication. This pattern is clearest under *Restricted Happiness* in the treatment-specific estimates (Appendix Table 24).

Social preferences address whether the opportunity to communicate has different value for participants who place more weight on fair treatment and reciprocity. Expressing anticipated feelings may provide a way to convey these concerns before becoming vulnerable to the trustee's choice. In the pooled comparison, the social-preference interactions are imprecise (Table 7). The treatment-specific estimates show a larger expected-return effect under *Flexible* among trustors who report stronger fairness preferences, with weaker evidence of variation by reciprocity preference (Appendix Table 25). Emotional intelligence and social preferences were measured after the trust decision.

5.2 Communication Environments

Cultural background and occupation address the study's motivation that social environments differ in how they permit emotional expression. Cultural background provides a broad comparison of

Table 7: Heterogeneity in the Effect of Access to Emotional Communication

Moderator	Trust	Expected return	Ambiguity aversion	a-insensitivity
Emotional intelligence				
Emotional intelligence index	-0.531	-7.070**	0.132	-0.026
	(0.471)	(2.779)	(0.389)	(0.380)
Self-emotion appraisal	-0.604**	-4.967**	0.165	-0.252
	(0.302)	(1.935)	(0.280)	(0.263)
Others' emotion appraisal	-0.106	-1.111	0.023	0.158
	(0.293)	(1.787)	(0.228)	(0.219)
Regulation of emotions	-0.400	-5.329***	-0.147	0.008
	(0.259)	(1.784)	(0.219)	(0.233)
Emotional labor	0.422	-0.887	0.422	-0.128
	(0.407)	(2.553)	(0.333)	(0.369)
Social preferences				
Fairness preference	0.234	3.128	0.200	0.269
	(0.330)	(2.002)	(0.269)	(0.262)
Reciprocity preference	0.074	1.727	0.114	0.132
	(0.408)	(2.467)	(0.426)	(0.356)
Typical observations	350	341	350	350

Notes: Entries report interaction coefficients from separate OLS regressions. The communication indicator equals one for Restricted Happiness, Restricted Disappointment, and Flexible and zero for Control. Each regression includes the communication indicator, the moderator, their interaction, and the baseline demographic controls used in the main analysis. The emotional-intelligence index averages the four component measures listed below it. Continuous moderators are normalized from zero to one and centered in the estimation sample. Social preferences and emotional-intelligence measures were collected after the trust decision. Robust standard errors are in parentheses. Significance levels: * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

settings in which emotional messages may carry different meanings. Appendix Table 26 shows suggestive differences in the Trust response to *Restricted Disappointment* and the ambiguity-aversion response to *Flexible*.

Occupation provides a closer connection to workplace display rules. I compare occupations associated with positive or supportive expression with those associated with professional neutrality. The clearest difference is in how trustors expect trustees to respond to a happy message. The expected-return effect under *Restricted Happiness* is smaller in the positive or supportive group (Appendix Table 27). Both classifications are coarse proxies for norms around emotional expression. The heterogeneity analyses are exploratory, and the interaction tests are two-sided and unadjusted for multiple comparisons.

6 Discussion

A communication opportunity may matter most for trustors who are close to choosing between Trust and No Trust. In this experiment, the certain payoff under No Trust makes Trust financially attractive over a wide range of anticipated returns. The ex-post payoff benchmark in Appendix Section E.1 illustrates this feature using realized returns. Varying the certain payoff in a future experiment would help assess whether emotional communication changes more decisions when the two options are closer in expected value.

The messages pair anticipated emotions with references to reciprocity or non-reciprocity. A happy message may convey an invitation to cooperate, while a disappointed message may signal an expectation or an anticipated social cost. Varying emotional wording while holding the information about reciprocity fixed would help distinguish these possibilities. Comparing chosen and assigned messages with the same wording would also help assess whether the opportunity to choose matters in its own right.

The experiment captures a single exchange with a limited set of messages. In an ongoing relationship, the trustor may also care about how a message affects future interactions with the trustee. A design that allows emotional feedback after the trustee's return could connect what trustors say before trusting with what they express after seeing the outcome. Eliciting beliefs before the trust decision would also allow the analysis to track how expectations relate to the choice as it is made.

7 Conclusion

Emotional expressions can shape how others respond, but the person expressing an emotion may also view the interaction differently. I examine this possibility in a trust game by varying whether trustors can send a happy message, a disappointed message, or choose between the two, with a no-message control. The incentivized belief-hedge task separates what trustors expect the trustee to return from how they evaluate ambiguity about that return.

The clearest pattern is in expected returns. Trustors in *Flexible* expect to receive \$0.75 more than

those in *Control* after adjusting for demographics. This is the largest expected-return estimate across the communication treatments and reaches the 5% level in an unadjusted one-sided test. The ambiguity estimates vary across treatments. They point toward greater ambiguity seeking in *Restricted Happiness* and *Flexible*, and the largest estimated reduction in a-insensitivity occurs in *Restricted Disappointment*. The separate preregistered contrasts all have adjusted p-values above 0.05.

Looking at beliefs and ambiguity attitudes separately helps interpret the trust decisions. Trustors with higher expected returns and lower ambiguity aversion choose Trust more often, yet the estimated effects of the communication treatments on Trust are imprecise. Trust is already common in *Control*, where the average expected return is well above the threshold at which Trust pays more than No Trust. On the trustee side, average returns are similar across conditions, even as returns bunch more at the \$12 focal point in *Restricted Happiness* and *Flexible*.

The study extends the analysis of emotional communication to the sender's decision to rely on someone else. In this setting, the opportunity to communicate is most clearly reflected in what trustors expect from the trustee, especially when they can choose what to express. Measuring those expectations alongside ambiguity attitudes and choices helps show where the effects of a communication opportunity are most apparent.

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A Analysis Following the Pre-registration

The three preregistered randomized comparisons use OLS regressions with the preregistered sample of participants passing both comprehension checks and the demographic controls of age, gender, education, income, employment activity, birth order, and occupation field. The tables report heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors. Tests are directional for pooled communication versus *Control* and two-sided for the other comparisons. Benjamini–Hochberg adjusted p-values are calculated within each comparison's four-outcome family.

None of the twelve comparisons is significant at the 5% level after adjustment. This does not establish that the effects are zero. These contrasts differ from the exploratory treatment-versus-control estimates in the main text, so the adjusted tests do not provide multiplicity-adjusted inference for those separate estimates.

Table 8: Preregistered Regression: Communication versus Control

	Expected return	Ambiguity aversion	a-insensitivity	Trust
Communication treatment	0.447	-0.042	-0.047	0.023
	(0.340)	(0.043)	(0.049)	(0.045)
Intercept	9.66	-0.13	0.50	0.80
	(0.86)	(0.11)	(0.11)	(0.11)
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	341	350	350	350
p-value	0.095	0.168	0.167	0.303
BH-adjusted p-value	0.224	0.224	0.224	0.303

Notes: Entries are OLS coefficients. Robust standard errors are in parentheses. The sample includes participants who passed both comprehension checks. Controls are age, gender, education, income, employment activity, birth order, and occupation field. The communication-versus-Control p-values use the preregistered directional tests. BH denotes Benjamini–Hochberg adjustment across the four outcomes.

Table 9: Preregistered Regression: Restricted Happiness versus Restricted Disappointment

	Expected return	Ambiguity aversion	a-insensitivity	Trust
Restricted Happiness	0.081	-0.085	0.004	0.020
	(0.485)	(0.052)	(0.059)	(0.063)
Intercept	11.84	-0.16	0.45	0.76
	(1.37)	(0.15)	(0.15)	(0.17)
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	172	174	174	174
p-value	0.867	0.105	0.947	0.746
BH-adjusted p-value	0.947	0.422	0.947	0.947

Notes: Entries are OLS coefficients. Robust standard errors are in parentheses. The sample includes participants who passed both comprehension checks and were assigned to one of the restricted-valence treatments. Controls are age, gender, education, income, employment activity, birth order, and occupation field. The p-values are two-sided. BH denotes Benjamini–Hochberg adjustment across the four outcomes.

Table 10: Preregistered Regression: Flexible versus Restricted Treatments

	Expected return	Ambiguity aversion	a-insensitivity	Trust
Flexible	0.351	-0.051	0.097	0.083
	(0.449)	(0.047)	(0.055)	(0.049)
Intercept	10.31	-0.13	0.39	0.74
	(1.02)	(0.11)	(0.12)	(0.12)
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	257	262	262	262
p-value	0.434	0.277	0.082	0.092
BH-adjusted p-value	0.434	0.370	0.183	0.183

Notes: Entries are OLS coefficients. Robust standard errors are in parentheses. The sample includes participants who passed both comprehension checks and were assigned to a communication treatment. Controls are age, gender, education, income, employment activity, birth order, and occupation field. The p-values are two-sided. BH denotes Benjamini–Hochberg adjustment across the four outcomes.

The preregistered emotional-expression analyses are reported in Tables 21 and 22. Communicated disappointment is amplified relative to self-reported intensity, while the corresponding happiness gap is not statistically distinguishable from zero. The Flexible-versus-Restricted gap comparisons are also statistically insignificant.

A.1 Weighted Restricted Benchmark

The preregistration also proposed comparing outcomes in *Flexible* with a synthetic restricted benchmark. This benchmark is the weighted average of outcomes in *Restricted Happiness* and *Restricted Disappointment*, using the shares of *Flexible* participants who chose a happy message and a disappointed message as weights. In this sample, those shares are 0.875 and 0.125. The contrast therefore asks whether outcomes in *Flexible* differ from what the restricted-treatment outcomes would predict at the observed message-choice mix.

Table 11 reports the two group means and their difference. The difference is estimated from a regression on treatment-arm indicators, with heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors. None of the four outcome differences is statistically distinguishable from zero, and none is significant after Benjamini–Hochberg adjustment. This is an exploratory benchmark rather than a separate randomized treatment effect. The weights come from participants' choices within *Flexible*, and the reported standard errors treat those estimated shares as fixed. The comparison should therefore be read as suggestive evidence about the role of message choice, not as a causal estimate of the effect of freedom itself.

Table 11: Counterfactual Comparison: Flexible versus Weighted Restricted Benchmark

Outcome	*Flexible* mean	Weighted restricted mean	Difference (SE)	Raw p	BH p	N
Trust	0.886	0.840	0.046 (0.048)	0.342	0.657	262
Ambiguity aversion	-0.116	-0.089	-0.027 (0.047)	0.569	0.759	262
a-insensitivity	0.413	0.333	0.080 (0.053)	0.128	0.511	262
Expected return	10.125	9.931	0.194 (0.436)	0.657	0.657	257

Notes: The weighted restricted mean is the average of the *Restricted Happiness* and *Restricted Disappointment* means, weighted by the shares of *Flexible* participants choosing a happy message (0.875) and a disappointed message (0.125). The difference is the coefficient from a regression on treatment-arm indicators without a constant, with the contrast defined as the *Flexible* mean minus this weighted benchmark. Robust standard errors are in parentheses. Raw p-values are two-sided; BH denotes Benjamini–Hochberg adjustment across the four outcomes. Standard errors treat the estimated message-choice shares as fixed.

B Measurement and Sample Sensitivity

B.1 Alternative Measurement of Beliefs

Optimism is the difference between the a-neutral probabilities assigned to the high- and low-return events. Table 12 reports the same treatment specifications as the expected-return columns in Table 3. Estimates are positive in all three communication conditions, but none is significant at the 5% level under the reported two-sided tests. Expected-return regressions instead report one-sided tests, so significance levels are not directly comparable across these tables. These exploratory estimates are not adjusted for multiple comparisons. The common positive signs show that the direction of the belief estimates also appears when beliefs are summarized by the balance of probability between high and low returns. The two-sided tests leave the regime-specific optimism effects uncertain.

Table 12: Treatment Effects on Optimism

	Optimism	
	(1)	(2)
Restricted Happiness	0.079	0.095*
	(0.055)	(0.056)
Restricted Disappointment	0.037	0.045
	(0.056)	(0.059)
Flexible	0.090	0.103*
	(0.058)	(0.060)
Intercept	0.046	0.134
	(0.037)	(0.117)
Controls	No	Yes
Adjusted R^2	0.000	-0.008
Observations	341	341

Notes: OLS regressions with robust standard errors in parentheses. Columns report estimates without controls and with demographic controls. Optimism is the difference between the probability assigned to the high-return event and the probability assigned to the low-return event, using the ambiguity-neutral measure. Treatment coefficients use two-sided tests. No multiplicity adjustment is applied. Significance levels are * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, and *** $p < 0.01$.

Table 13 shows that optimism is positively associated with trust, while ambiguity aversion is negatively associated with trust; a-insensitivity and its interaction with optimism are not statistically significant. This broadly matches the associations in Table 4. Because these measures were elicited after the trust decision, the estimates describe associations and do not establish a causal mechanism.

Table 13: Trust, Ambiguity Attitudes, and Optimism

	Trust				
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Ambiguity aversion	-0.183***		-0.148**	-0.147**	-0.164**
	(0.064)		(0.062)	(0.062)	(0.066)
A-insensitivity	0.007		0.027	0.026	0.023
	(0.060)		(0.059)	(0.062)	(0.063)
Optimism (high minus low)		0.266***	0.253***	0.244***	0.208***
		(0.055)	(0.055)	(0.071)	(0.077)
Optimism × A-insensitivity				0.023	-0.013
				(0.143)	(0.147)
Control variables	No	No	No	No	Yes
Observations	341	341	341	341	341
R-squared	0.027	0.080	0.098	0.098	0.226

Notes: Linear probability models with robust standard errors in parentheses. The dependent variable equals one for Trust. Optimism is $p_H - p_L$, the difference between the a-neutral probabilities assigned to the high- and low-return events. All columns use the same complete-case subset of the comprehension-passing main sample. Column (1) includes the two ambiguity-attitude indices; column (2) includes optimism; column (3) includes all three measures; column (4) adds the optimism-by-A-insensitivity interaction; and column (5) adds fairness and reciprocity preferences, the four emotional-intelligence components, and the prespecified demographic controls. Optimism and ambiguity attitudes were elicited after the trust decision, so these coefficients describe post-decision associations and do not identify causal mediation. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

B.2 Hierarchical Bayesian Model

Following Baillon et al. (2026), the hierarchical Bayesian model treats each participant's elicited matching probabilities as noisy measurements of their underlying beliefs and ambiguity attitudes. It estimates participant-level values jointly with population distributions, so responses that are less informative are partially pooled toward the population pattern, while more informative responses retain more individual variation. This differs from the baseline belief-hedge calculation, which recovers each participant's ambiguity-neutral beliefs and ambiguity indices directly from their six matching probabilities. The Bayesian approach therefore accounts explicitly for response noise and constrains recovered values to admissible ranges, while targeting the same underlying belief and ambiguity measures.

Table 14 repeats Table 3's treatment-indicator regressions using the hierarchical Bayesian measures. Expected-return coefficients are positive across the three treatments. The controlled estimate under *Flexible* is \$0.768, compared with \$0.745 using the baseline measure. The controlled a-insensitivity coefficient under *Restricted Disappointment* remains negative but is smaller, at -0.050 rather than -0.092. The similarity of the Flexible estimates supports the expected-return result across the two recovery methods. For Restricted Disappointment, the sign is stable across methods, while the smaller Bayesian estimate qualifies the size of the reduction in a-insensitivity. Trust is not re-measured and its estimates are unchanged. These OLS estimates use posterior means as outcomes, so their robust standard errors do not incorporate uncertainty in the first-stage posterior estimates.

Table 14: Treatment Effects Using Hierarchical Bayesian Measures

	Expected return		Ambiguity aversion		**a**-insensitivity	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Restricted Happiness	0.353	0.499*	-0.048	-0.051	-0.030	-0.031
	(0.328)	(0.351)	(0.046)	(0.048)	(0.029)	(0.032)
Restricted Disappointment	0.092	0.196	0.013	0.021	-0.050*	-0.050*
	(0.351)	(0.367)	(0.045)	(0.045)	(0.031)	(0.032)
Flexible	0.658**	0.768**	-0.068*	-0.070*	-0.020	-0.030
	(0.337)	(0.358)	(0.045)	(0.052)	(0.032)	(0.033)
Intercept	9.533	10.115	-0.043	-0.142	0.516	0.497
	(0.199)	(0.690)	(0.033)	(0.103)	(0.021)	(0.064)
Controls	No	Yes	No	Yes	No	Yes
Adjusted R^2	0.003	0.000	0.004	0.002	-0.001	0.044
Observations	350	350	350	350	350	350

Notes: OLS regressions with robust standard errors in parentheses. Columns report estimates without controls and with the demographic controls used in Table 3. Expected return is calculated from the posterior-mean probabilities for low, middle, and high returns, weighted by the corresponding interval midpoints. Ambiguity aversion and a-insensitivity are posterior-mean neo-additive indices. Regressions use these posterior means as outcomes; standard errors do not propagate posterior estimation uncertainty. Treatment-versus-Control tests are one-sided in the hypothesized direction. Significance levels are * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, and *** $p < 0.01$.

B.3 Sample Sensitivity

The broader sample yields a smaller estimated expected-return effect under *Flexible*, while the controlled a-insensitivity coefficient under *Restricted Disappointment* is nearly unchanged. Table 15 repeats the treatment-indicator specifications in Table 3 among participants who passed at least one comprehension check. The sample includes 396 participants for trust and the ambiguity measures; expected-return estimates use 386 participants because valid expected returns are unavailable for everyone. The comparison probes how the results depend on requiring participants to pass both checks. It points to greater sample sensitivity for the size of the Flexible belief estimate than for the Restricted Disappointment estimate of a-insensitivity. Trust estimates remain imprecise even with the broader sample.

Table 15: Main Regression Results: Participants Passing at Least One Comprehension Check

	Expected return		Ambiguity aversion		**a**-insensitivity		Trust	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Restricted Happiness	0.345	0.505*	-0.074*	-0.078*	-0.081*	-0.062	-0.008	-0.011
	(0.379)	(0.385)	(0.048)	(0.051)	(0.053)	(0.056)	(0.054)	(0.056)
Restricted Disappointment	0.080	0.096	-0.000	0.010	-0.115**	-0.092*	-0.005	-0.016
	(0.389)	(0.406)	(0.046)	(0.047)	(0.054)	(0.058)	(0.055)	(0.055)
Flexible	0.365	0.414	-0.071*	-0.068	0.009	0.015	0.043	0.033
	(0.402)	(0.423)	(0.048)	(0.054)	(0.053)	(0.057)	(0.051)	(0.052)
Intercept	9.609	10.504	-0.039	-0.149	0.418	0.447	0.828	0.867
	(0.256)	(0.780)	(0.033)	(0.104)	(0.037)	(0.110)	(0.038)	(0.102)
Controls	No	Yes	No	Yes	No	Yes	No	Yes
Adjusted R-squared	-0.005	-0.008	0.004	0.018	0.012	0.015	-0.004	-0.003
Observations	386	386	396	396	396	396	396	396

Notes: OLS regressions with robust standard errors in parentheses. The sample includes participants who passed at least one of the two comprehension checks. Columns report estimates without controls and with the demographic controls used in Table 3. Treatment-versus-Control tests are one-sided in the hypothesized direction. Significance levels are * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, and *** $p < 0.01$. Outcome-specific sample sizes vary because some measures are missing. This broader-sample comparison is a sample-sensitivity check and does not change the randomized treatment assignment.

Table 16: Treatment Effects with Social-Preference and Emotional-Intelligence Controls

	Expected return	Ambiguity aversion	a-insensitivity	Trust
Restricted Happiness	0.680*	-0.064	-0.061	0.017
	(0.413)	(0.054)	(0.059)	(0.057)
Restricted Disappointment	0.321	0.007	-0.095*	-0.016
	(0.449)	(0.049)	(0.062)	(0.060)
Flexible	0.653*	-0.084*	0.000	0.027
	(0.463)	(0.057)	(0.063)	(0.052)
Demographic controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Social-preference controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Emotional-intelligence controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Adjusted R^2	0.002	-0.003	-0.000	0.037
Observations	341	350	350	350

Notes: OLS regressions include three treatment indicators, with Control omitted. Demographic controls match Table 3. Social-preference controls are fairness and reciprocity preference. Emotional-intelligence controls are self-emotion appraisal, others' emotion appraisal, emotion regulation, and emotional labor. These measures were collected after the trust decision. Robust standard errors are in parentheses. Treatment-versus-Control tests are one-sided in the hypothesized direction, matching Table 3. Tests are unadjusted for multiple testing. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

C Balance Checks

Table 17 reports comprehension-check pass rates and completion times by treatment. Table 18 reports the pretreatment demographic variables used as baseline controls.

Table 17: Completion Time and Comprehension Checks by Treatment

Measure	Full	Control	Restricted Happiness	Restricted Disappointment	Flexible
Observations	400	99	101	97	103
Trust comprehension check	394 (98.5%)	99 (100.0%)	99 (98.0%)	95 (97.9%)	101 (98.1%)
Choice comprehension check	352 (88.0%)	88 (88.9%)	90 (89.1%)	86 (88.7%)	88 (85.4%)
Passed both comprehension checks	350 (87.5%)	88 (88.9%)	89 (88.1%)	85 (87.6%)	88 (85.4%)
Completion time (minutes)	17.66	15.78	17.81	19.03	18.03
Completion time SD	9.41	9.99	8.64	8.97	9.78

Notes: The trust comprehension check assesses participants' understanding of the modified trust-game rules. The choice comprehension check assesses participants' understanding of the belief-hedge method. The main sample consists of participants who passed both checks. Completion time is measured in minutes. Comprehension entries report counts, with treatment shares in parentheses.

Table 18: Pretreatment Covariate Balance in the Main Sample

Covariate	Control	Restricted Happiness	Restricted Disappointment	Flexible	N
Age	39.58	41.48	39.94	40.64	350
Woman	0.51	0.55	0.47	0.50	350
Non-binary	0.01	0.02	0.02	0.01	350
Graduate degree	0.20	0.22	0.20	0.20	350
Student	0.06	0.03	0.07	0.01	350
Working full-time	0.50	0.46	0.46	0.60	350
Only child	0.10	0.11	0.14	0.12	350
First-born	0.33	0.35	0.25	0.36	350
Native English speaker	0.98	0.92	0.99	0.93	350
Asian cultural background	0.12	0.10	0.08	0.16	350
Science major	0.34	0.39	0.31	0.30	350
Computer and information sciences	0.12	0.17	0.16	0.12	350
Life sciences and health	0.16	0.10	0.09	0.10	350
Engineering	0.06	0.07	0.05	0.07	350
Physical sciences	0.00	0.06	0.00	0.00	350

Notes: Entries under the treatment arms are means. For indicator variables, they are sample proportions. "Asian cultural background" includes East Asian, Southeast Asian, and South Asian. "Science major" includes computer and information sciences, life sciences and health, engineering, and physical sciences. The joint multinomial-logit Wald test of all pretreatment covariates gives $\chi^2(111) = 77.26$ with $p = 0.994$.

Table 19: Completion Time by Trust Choice and Treatment

Sample	Trust	No trust	p-value
Full sample	17.48	18.59	0.41
Control	15.87	15.34	0.84
Restricted Happiness	16.94	21.85	0.06
Restricted Disappointment	19.02	19.11	0.97
Flexible	18.09	17.60	0.87

Notes: Completion time is measured in minutes. The final column reports the Welch two-sample t-test p-value for the difference in mean completion time.

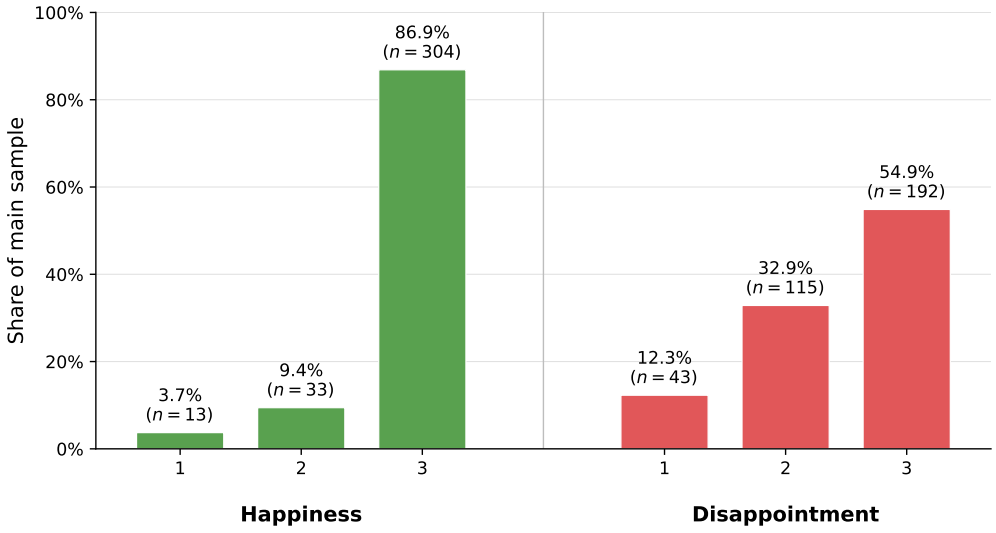
D Communication Choices and Emotional Responses

D.1 Message Intensity and Emotional Responses

D.1.1 Anticipated Emotion and Communicated Expression

Participants anticipate strong emotions before learning their communication options. Figure 6 shows that 86.9% expected to feel very happy if their trust was reciprocated, whereas 54.9% expected to feel very disappointed if it was not. The two ratings are positively but modestly correlated (Spearman's $\rho = 0.22$, $p < 0.001$, $N = 350$), indicating that participants who anticipated stronger happiness also tended to anticipate stronger disappointment.

Figure 6: Self-reported anticipated emotion intensity.



Notes: The figure uses the main sample ($N = 350$). Intensity is coded 1 = slightly, 2 = moderately, and 3 = very. Bars show the share selecting each intensity, with counts above the bars. Both measures were elicited before treatment assignment and the trust decision.

Participants usually choose high-intensity messages. In the restricted treatments, 88.8% of participants in *Restricted Happiness* selected "very happy," while 63.5% in *Restricted Disappointment* selected "very disappointed." In *Flexible*, 94.8% of happiness choosers selected "very happy," and 72.7% of disappointment choosers selected "very disappointed." High-intensity messages are thus especially common for happiness.

The pre-registered expression tests find amplification of disappointment. The gap is statistically indistinguishable from zero for happy messages and positive for disappointed messages at the 1% level (Appendix Table 21). Differences between *Flexible* and restricted treatments are statistically indistinguishable from zero for either valence (Appendix Table 22). The clearest pattern is the amplification of disappointment when it becomes communicative. Message intensity captures one

margin of expression, while psychological or relational communication costs may also be reflected in ambiguity attitudes toward the interaction.

D.1.2 Meaning and Reception of Messages

Participants describe both expressive and strategic reasons for their messages. An exploratory qualitative reading of responses from participants who passed both comprehension checks reveals recurring references to honest expression, communicating expectations, and encouraging reciprocity. Participants who kept the same intensity explain that the message reflects how they would feel, while some who changed it describe trying to persuade the trustee or avoiding excessive pressure. For example, one participant writes, "i thought the higher intensity could influence things in my favor," and another explains, "i wanted to persuade my partner to reciprocate my trust, so i exaggerated my feeling of disappointment if they did not." Dismissing communication as useless is not a recurring explanation, although one participant expresses distrust and says that "it feels kind of irrelevant." These responses suggest that participants attach expressive or strategic meaning to their messages. They do not establish that participants expect a substantial effect. The questions ask why participants chose an intensity, rather than directly asking whether communication works, and an attempt to persuade remains consistent with communicating just in case. The open texts therefore provide supporting evidence of engagement and perceived potential influence, while leaving the effectiveness of the messages to be assessed using the behavioral outcomes.

Table 20 reports the distribution of communicated intensity by treatment. Tables 21 and 22 report the pre-registered expression comparisons.

Table 20: Communicated Intensities by Treatment

Intensity	Full sample	Restricted Happiness	Restricted Disappointment	Flexible	p-value
Slightly	4.6%	2.2%	10.6%	1.1%	
Moderately	13.7%	9.0%	25.9%	6.8%	< 0.001
Very	81.7%	88.8%	63.5%	92.0%	
Observations	262	89	85	88	

Notes: The table reports communicated emotional intensity in the main sample, overall and by randomized communication treatment. The p-value is from a Pearson chi-squared test of independence between treatment assignment and communicated intensity.

Table 21: Communicated versus Self-Reported Emotional Intensity

Message valence	N	Positive	Zero	Negative	Wilcoxon p-value
Happy	166	11	149	6	0.225
Disappointed	96	21	71	4	< 0.001

Notes: The revelation gap equals communicated intensity minus self-reported intensity. Positive values indicate exaggeration and negative values indicate suppression. The final column reports two-sided Wilcoxon signed-rank tests of whether the revelation gap equals zero. The sample includes participants in the emotion treatments who passed the comprehension checks.

Table 22: Flexible Communication and the Emotional Expression Gap

	Revelation gap
Flexible revelation	-0.033
	(0.134)
Happy message	-0.157*
	(0.090)
Flexible revelation × Happy message	0.012
	(0.164)
Flexible effect among disappointed messages: p-value	0.805
Flexible effect among happy messages: p-value	0.805
Controls	Yes
Observations	262
R^2	0.106

Notes: OLS estimates with the revelation gap (communicated minus self-reported intensity) as the dependent variable. Restricted disappointed messages form the reference group. Controls include age, gender, culture, education, income, employment activity, birth order, and occupation. Robust standard errors are in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

E Additional Trustee Results

Table 23: Distribution of Trustee Returns by Randomized Trustor Condition

				Return amount			
Condition	Mean	Median	Variance	$10	$11	$12	$10–$12
Control	10.88	11	16.52	21.59%	21.59%	29.55%	72.73%
Restricted Happiness	11.01	12	10.40	17.98%	19.10%	44.94%**	82.02%
Restricted Disappointment	10.55	11	10.11	16.47%	24.71%	32.94%	74.12%
Flexible	10.78	12	14.93	11.36%	20.45%	47.73%**	79.55%

Notes: The sample consists of 350 trustors who passed both comprehension checks, matched to trustee return decisions. Returns range from $0 to $24. Variance is the sample variance. Return 10–12 includes returns of $10, $11, or $12. Percentages are calculated within randomized trustor condition. Stars indicate two-sided Fisher exact tests comparing each communication treatment with *Control*: * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

E.1 Ex-post Payoff Benchmark

Trust would have yielded a higher monetary payoff in 96% of matched cases. No Trust pays the trustor $5, while Trust pays $2 plus the trustee's return, so Trust is more profitable whenever the return exceeds $3. This condition holds for 336 of the 350 matched decisions. The remaining 14 returns are below $3, and none equals $3. This is an ex-post benchmark rather than the proportion who should necessarily have trusted when choosing under uncertainty. For a risk-neutral trustor concerned only with monetary payoff, the decision depends on whether the expected return exceeds $3.

F Exploratory Heterogeneity

This section reports the full set of participant-characteristic comparisons, including pooled communication and treatment-specific interactions. The analyses are exploratory and the interaction tests are two-sided and unadjusted for multiple comparisons. Emotional intelligence and social preferences were collected after the trust decision and should not be interpreted as pretreatment moderators.

F.1 Emotional Intelligence and Social Preferences

Table 24 reports the emotional-intelligence interactions separately for each treatment. Each column uses a separate moderator, allowing the association with treatment effects to differ across the index and its four components.

Table 24: Treatment Interactions with Emotional Intelligence

Outcome	Treatment	Emotional intelligence index	Self-emotion appraisal	Others' emotion appraisal	Emotion regulation	Emotional labor
Trust	Restricted Happiness	-1.551**	-0.976**	-0.900**	-0.516*	0.433
		(0.641)	(0.399)	(0.357)	(0.300)	(0.510)
	Restricted Disappointment	-0.652	-0.630*	-0.006	-0.438	0.104
		(0.499)	(0.343)	(0.334)	(0.291)	(0.476)
	Flexible	0.645	0.342	0.480	-0.256	1.024**
		(0.580)	(0.421)	(0.378)	(0.285)	(0.486)
Ambiguity aversion	Restricted Happiness	0.217	-0.098	0.007	-0.081	0.708
		(0.612)	(0.374)	(0.344)	(0.312)	(0.439)
	Restricted Disappointment	0.249	0.140	-0.008	-0.015	0.426
		(0.479)	(0.337)	(0.284)	(0.245)	(0.408)
	Flexible	-0.172	0.141	0.109	-0.425*	0.210
		(0.492)	(0.368)	(0.276)	(0.248)	(0.401)
a-insensitivity	Restricted Happiness	-0.064	-0.021	0.180	-0.209	0.011
		(0.526)	(0.397)	(0.284)	(0.260)	(0.459)
	Restricted Disappointment	-0.531	-0.781**	-0.037	-0.123	-0.146
		(0.516)	(0.324)	(0.326)	(0.325)	(0.470)
	Flexible	-0.046	-0.113	-0.026	0.145	-0.327
		(0.498)	(0.356)	(0.260)	(0.277)	(0.454)
Expected return	Restricted Happiness	-8.988**	-4.511*	-2.302	-5.931**	-1.309
		(4.130)	(2.574)	(2.768)	(2.323)	(3.640)
	Restricted Disappointment	-5.260	-4.185*	-0.141	-3.007	-4.999*
		(3.674)	(2.398)	(2.111)	(2.206)	(3.005)
	Flexible	-3.616	-3.837	0.291	-6.016**	5.512
		(3.785)	(3.494)	(2.488)	(2.331)	(3.346)

Notes: Entries are treatment-by-emotional-intelligence interaction coefficients from separate OLS regressions for each outcome and moderator. Each regression includes the three treatment indicators, the centered moderator, all three treatment-by-moderator interactions, and the demographic controls used in Table 3. Control is the omitted condition. The index averages the four component measures. Measures are scaled from zero to one. The main sample includes participants passing both comprehension checks. Each model has 350 observations, except expected-return models, which have 341. Emotional intelligence was measured after the trust decision. Robust standard errors are in parentheses. Tests are two-sided and unadjusted for multiple testing. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table 25 reports the treatment interactions with fairness and reciprocity preferences, estimated separately for each moderator. The estimates include differences in expected return, Trust, and

a-insensitivity, alongside imprecisely estimated interactions. These comparisons do not establish separate causal mechanisms.

Table 25: Treatment Interactions with Social Preferences

Outcome	Treatment	Fairness preference	Reciprocity preference
Trust	Restricted Happiness	-0.101	-0.089
		(0.402)	(0.544)
	Restricted Disappointment	0.051	-0.206
		(0.429)	(0.535)
	Flexible	0.725*	0.740
		(0.370)	(0.561)
Ambiguity aversion	Restricted Happiness	-0.097	-0.211
		(0.369)	(0.580)
	Restricted Disappointment	0.326	0.535
		(0.373)	(0.556)
	Flexible	0.156	-0.303
		(0.308)	(0.542)
a-insensitivity	Restricted Happiness	0.906***	0.187
		(0.332)	(0.471)
	Restricted Disappointment	-0.196	0.114
		(0.415)	(0.529)
	Flexible	0.053	0.021
		(0.312)	(0.464)
Expected return	Restricted Happiness	2.994	4.955
		(2.666)	(3.683)
	Restricted Disappointment	0.425	-0.062
		(2.891)	(3.500)
	Flexible	6.522***	1.953
		(2.350)	(3.598)

Notes: Entries report treatment-by-moderator interaction coefficients from separate OLS regressions. Each regression includes the three treatment indicators, the centered social-preference measure, its interactions with all three treatments, and demographic controls matching Table 3. Moderators are continuous and normalized to the zero-to-one scale. Coefficients show how the treatment effect changes across the moderator range. Robust standard errors are in parentheses. Tests are two-sided and unadjusted for multiple testing. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

F.2 Cultural Background

Cultural background may capture differences in norms around emotional expression. I examine whether communication effects vary across broad cultural-background groups and report the full estimates in Table 26. This classification is a coarse proxy for communication norms, so the comparison is exploratory.

Table 26: Treatment Effects by Collectivist Cultural-Background Proxy

Outcome	Treatment	Collectivist	Individualistic	Difference
Trust	Restricted Happiness	-0.031	0.064	-0.095
		(0.123)	(0.066)	(0.139)
	Restricted Disappointment	-0.225*	0.053	-0.279*
		(0.126)	(0.068)	(0.146)
	Flexible	0.075	0.030	0.045
		(0.092)	(0.067)	(0.116)
Ambiguity aversion	Restricted Happiness	-0.032	-0.129*	0.097
		(0.109)	(0.069)	(0.135)
	Restricted Disappointment	-0.012	0.007	-0.019
		(0.114)	(0.060)	(0.131)
	Flexible	-0.282**	-0.019	-0.262*
		(0.124)	(0.059)	(0.133)
a-insensitivity	Restricted Happiness	-0.140	-0.052	-0.088
		(0.099)	(0.076)	(0.122)
	Restricted Disappointment	-0.130	-0.095	-0.034
		(0.128)	(0.076)	(0.149)
	Flexible	0.123	-0.058	0.180
		(0.102)	(0.078)	(0.125)
Expected return	Restricted Happiness	0.338	0.748	-0.410
		(0.731)	(0.547)	(0.919)
	Restricted Disappointment	1.007	-0.038	1.045
		(0.783)	(0.571)	(0.966)
	Flexible	0.540	0.726	-0.185
		(0.777)	(0.573)	(0.959)
Observations		96	222	

Notes: Entries report treatment effects relative to Control with heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors in parentheses. The Difference column reports the treatment-by-background interaction. The individualistic proxy contains European/North American respondents. The collectivist proxy contains African, East Asian, South Asian, Southeast Asian, Latin American, and Middle Eastern or North African respondents. Mixed, Other, and Prefer-not-to-say backgrounds are excluded. All models include the demographic controls and detailed cultural-background categories; cultural background is an addition to the pre-registered control set. The classification is a coarse exploratory proxy rather than an individual-level measure of cultural orientation. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

F.3 Occupations

Occupation may proxy the emotional display rules participants encounter at work. I examine whether communication effects differ between participants in positive/supportive occupations and those in professional-neutrality occupations. Table 27 reports the full estimates. These occupational groups provide a coarse measure of workplace norms, so the analysis is exploratory.

Table 27: Treatment Effects by Occupation-Based Emotional Display Regime

Outcome	Treatment	Positive/supportive	Professional neutrality	Other/no clear rule	Difference
Trust	Restricted Happiness	0.145	-0.010	-0.168	0.155
		(0.098)	(0.077)	(0.140)	(0.120)
	Restricted Disappointment	0.066	-0.078	0.017	0.145
		(0.099)	(0.088)	(0.120)	(0.134)
	Flexible	0.098	0.013	-0.015	0.086
		(0.092)	(0.077)	(0.127)	(0.119)
Ambiguity aversion	Restricted Happiness	-0.172**	-0.043	0.165	-0.129
		(0.080)	(0.082)	(0.108)	(0.112)
	Restricted Disappointment	-0.110	0.069	0.177*	-0.180
		(0.078)	(0.082)	(0.094)	(0.115)
	Flexible	-0.108	-0.082	0.079	-0.026
		(0.082)	(0.084)	(0.138)	(0.114)
a-insensitivity	Restricted Happiness	0.051	-0.119	-0.069	0.169
		(0.088)	(0.094)	(0.122)	(0.127)
	Restricted Disappointment	-0.199*	-0.038	-0.017	-0.161
		(0.102)	(0.095)	(0.137)	(0.141)
	Flexible	0.007	0.006	0.077	0.002
		(0.099)	(0.091)	(0.119)	(0.133)
Expected return	Restricted Happiness	0.108	1.966***	-2.104*	-1.858**
		(0.682)	(0.589)	(1.133)	(0.908)
	Restricted Disappointment	0.627	0.758	-1.707	-0.132
		(0.706)	(0.658)	(1.135)	(0.976)
	Flexible	0.435	1.043*	-0.181	-0.609
		(0.789)	(0.570)	(1.343)	(0.971)
Observations		127	160	63	

Notes: Entries report treatment effects relative to Control with heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors in parentheses. Positive/supportive occupations are those in which workers are commonly expected to display friendliness, empathy, reassurance, or calmness and to suppress negative reactions. Professional-neutrality occupations are those emphasizing restrained, controlled, objective, or emotionally detached communication rather than overt emotional expression. Other/no-clear-rule includes respondents without a currently identifiable occupational display rule or with insufficient occupational information. Difference reports Positive/supportive minus Professional neutrality. Occupational regimes are exploratory proxies constructed from broad occupation fields and manually classified free-text responses. All models include the preregistered demographic controls, including the original occupation categories. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.